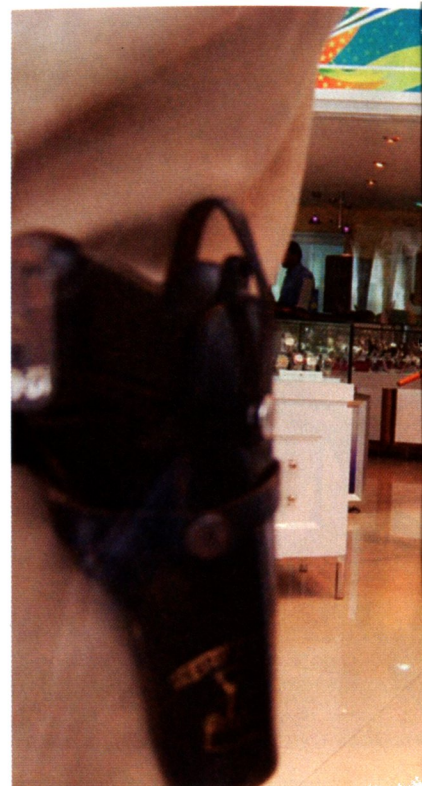


IN PRISON AND IN CONTROL

Some of the most dreaded names of the Mumbai underworld continue to be as powerful inside jails as they were outside



V/O DAY



REMOTE CONTROL: (Left) Rao being taken to court; (above) Titan showroom in Mulund, (right) ACP Crime Branch, Bharti

■ By Swati Mathur

On a sultry June afternoon, the World of Titan showroom in Mumbai's central suburbs received two seemingly ordinary visitors. Dressed like any regular customers, they caught the manager off-guard when they, instead of inquiring about the latest collection of watches, asked about a phone call from "Virji bhai". When the manager responded in the negative, the duo pulled out their revolvers and fired two rounds, shattering the glass in the store. Then, they calmly walked out and fled in an autorickshaw. Two days later, the anti-extortion cell of the Mumbai Police Crime Branch arrested six people—the same group involved in the firing incident. Upon detailed interrogations, the police dis-

covered that they were hired by Sachin Gajanand Shete, a Byculla jail inmate.

Inside the guarded walls of Maharashtra prisons, it is business as usual for inmates like Shete and other gangsters like Dharmesh Shah and D.K. Rao—of course with a little help from officers on duty. From mobile phones and knives to branded clothes and packets of Marlborough Lights, just about everything a prisoner may need is smuggled into high security prisons. In a raid conducted on the Byculla jail inmates, while the accused were found in possession of mobile phone chargers and knives, four officers and four constables were suspended for aiding and abetting their activities. "We have filed fresh cases of Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA) against Shete and his gang members. We are

gathering more evidence against him and will file a charge-sheet soon," says Deven Bharti, additional commissioner of police, Crime Branch. The police have also revealed that while Shete is the local kingpin, the real boss, gangster-on-the-run Bunty Pandey, issues extortion orders to builders, jewellery shop owners and hoteliers. The focus of the underworld has moved from Bollywood to local businessmen, who are easy prey as compared to well-connected film personalities.

The incident involving Shete has brought into focus the sorry state of affairs that exist within the state's central and district prisons. The exchange of information and orders are passed, often, when relatives and lawyers visit the inmates twice every week. There are also the visits to the court for hear-